

Amy Flynn

May 9, 2022

I. Data and Surveillance

Introduced by Shoshana Zuboff in *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*, the term surveillance capitalism refers to a system where personal private data acts as raw material used to build models that predict human behavior, which corporations use to manipulate consumers. Our actions on the Internet produce collateral data Zuboff refers to as ‘behavioral surplus’ and includes things like watch-time, phrasing, punctuation, and click traces that allow predictive algorithms to be built. Corporations that can predict consumer behavior by profile can then target and manipulate unknowing consumers by their private needs and desires; as Zuboff writes, “instead of labor, surveillance capitalism feeds on every aspect of every human’s experience.” (Zuboff 14) This use of behavioral surplus was originally meant to improve Google search engine functionality and then as a means to meet high-profit motives with basic targeted advertising. Subsequently, it has spiraled into a new condition of platform capitalism based on the mass surveillance of consumers and violation of privacy rights.

There are even broader ramifications of technology being used in this way. In his “Why Privacy Matters” TED Talk, Glenn Greenwald references the 18th-century philosopher Jeremy Bentham’s concept of the panopticon. Essentially, it is a cylindrical prison surveilled by a cylindrical guard tower in the center with a 360-degree view of all the prisoners and no way for the prisoners to see in. This forces the prisoners to obey constantly because of the possibility of being watched at any moment. As Greenwald explains, surveillance is an extremely powerful tool for those in power because “mass surveillance creates a prison ... much more effective than brute force could ever be.” (7:57) This is extremely concerning considering the world knows that

the United States government surveils citizens, arguably well past what the Constitution allows. Due to Edward Snowden, documents were released proving the National Security Agency was collecting telephone records and metadata of citizens, tapping fiber-optic cables to track phone and internet use, and using mechanisms like PRISM to tap into the backend of data servers of big corporations like Facebook, Apple, and Google. Safety is an important concern, and national security was the NSA's main defense backed by the US government. However, there is an incredibly fine line between using invasive methods to keep citizens safe and violating their constitutional rights. It also begs the question of how far this technology could go towards nefarious means. For example, when Black Lives Matter protesters were being put on terrorist watch lists, many people were displeased by the implication that social change could be summarily halted by those who have the technology to do so.

To me, the lack of transparency between governments and citizens as well as corporations and consumers is one of the most concerning issues with this mass data collection of citizens. Interestingly, Snowden himself writes in his autobiography that it was actually because “the system of near-universal surveillance had been set up not just without our consent, but in a way that deliberately hid every aspect of its programs from our knowledge,” that made him need to come forward. (Snowden 8) Economically, Zuboff references this nuance of surveillance capitalism by describing it as a one-way mirror where consumers are at the mercy of firms who can continue to increase profit at the expense of consumer rights. Socially, the immense power imbalance it creates between the public and those who hold this exponentially advanced technology could have detrimental implications. It is hard to imagine a true democracy where the richest, most powerful regimes control machine intelligence with the power to surveil and manipulate the population, without them even knowing.

II. Policy Alternatives

Surveillance capitalism has extremely concerning implications for our economy and democracy overall, but there have been ways proposed to reverse some of the damage being done. In her book *Abolish Silicon Valley*, Wendy Liu goes over a multitude of them, but two stuck out to me specifically. The first is the reclaiming of public service, or in other words the prioritization of things that advance society rather than the prioritization of personal profit. The thing is that “technology is never developed in a vacuum,” and the course of its development depends entirely on the basis of its funding. (Liu 134) Capital equals power and the end goal is almost always more profit, so those with the money to sway development depending on the current political or personal motives can do so. If more emphasis was put on rejuvenating the public sector, technology could be developed not to satisfy the ever-demanding profit motive for a few, but to help society as a whole.

Liu also proposes the concept of reclaiming work as a way to undo some of the adverse effects of surveillance capitalism. One of the biggest problems with the current system is the market imbalance it creates between those in power and everyone else, especially workers. In order to accumulate inordinate wealth on the scale we see today, profit has to start coming from cutting corners. This could be the manipulation of consumers, mistreatment of workers, the disregard of negative externalities, all to make more money for people who already have more than most others. Co-ops are one way that I think the reclamation of work could be accomplished, as this business model gives workers more power over company operations to function more democratically. It could even be done with the same technology that surveillance capitalism relies on, as Juliet Schor points out in her book *After the Gig* when she writes, “Algorithms take over many of the functions of management, which reduces costs and raises

incomes. While this can be problematic when the algorithms are constructed to make profits for owners, if they are built with workers' interests in mind, it can be a benefit.” (246) Correcting these market imbalances through the reclamation of work using the same technology that is currently available would be an ideal way to see this vision through.

However, I believe the obstacles regarding making real progress with changing the current system are our social priorities. It is true that co-ops could work, but I find it hard to successfully imagine in our extremely profit-driven, race-to-the-top culture. The thing is that technology is utilized according to political and economic motives and even though the technology surveillance capitalism relies on is used now for spying and violating privacy rights, it is not inherently bad technology. In *Big Data's Radical Potential*, Pankaj Mehta explains this best when he says “when the profit motive is muted, big data can be readily harnessed for the benefit of society as a whole.” (Mehta) With the right policy alternatives and social change, big data could actually maximize human lives. Mehta references workers using management algorithms on behalf of themselves, and the insurmountable scientific progress that can be made with the use of our current technology. To do this, I think we have to societally shift our priorities away from profit tied up in the hands of a few and use our advanced resources and technology to improve people's real daily lives. I do not know if such a culture switch is in our near future, but I do think that there is a potential for the social benefits technology can have to be recognized and embraced as frustration grows with our current state of affairs.

Works Cited

Greenwald, Glenn. *Why Privacy Matters*. TEDGlobal 2014

https://www.ted.com/talks/glenn_greenwald_why_privacy_matters?language=en

Liu, Wendy. *Abolish Silicon Valley: How to Liberate Technology from Capitalism*. Repeater Books / Watkins Media Ltd, 2020.

Mehta, Pankaj. *Big Data's Radical Potential*. Jacobin, 2015.

Schor, Juliet. *After the Gig: How the Sharing Economy Got Hijacked and How to Win It Back*. University of California Press, 2020.

Snowden, Edward J. *Permanent Record: How One Man Exposed the Truth about Government Spying and Digital Security*. Henry Holt and Company, 2021.

Zuboff, Shoshana. *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power*. Public Affairs, 2020.